

Call me Ishmael; finding a damp, drizzly November in my soul, I take to the ship and set my course for the watery part of the world.



No, when I go to sea, I go as a simple sailor right before the mast, content to be ordered about and to be paid for it.



By reason of these things, I fixed on a whaling voyage—the great whale and the wild, distant seas swayed me, and the wonder-world swung open.



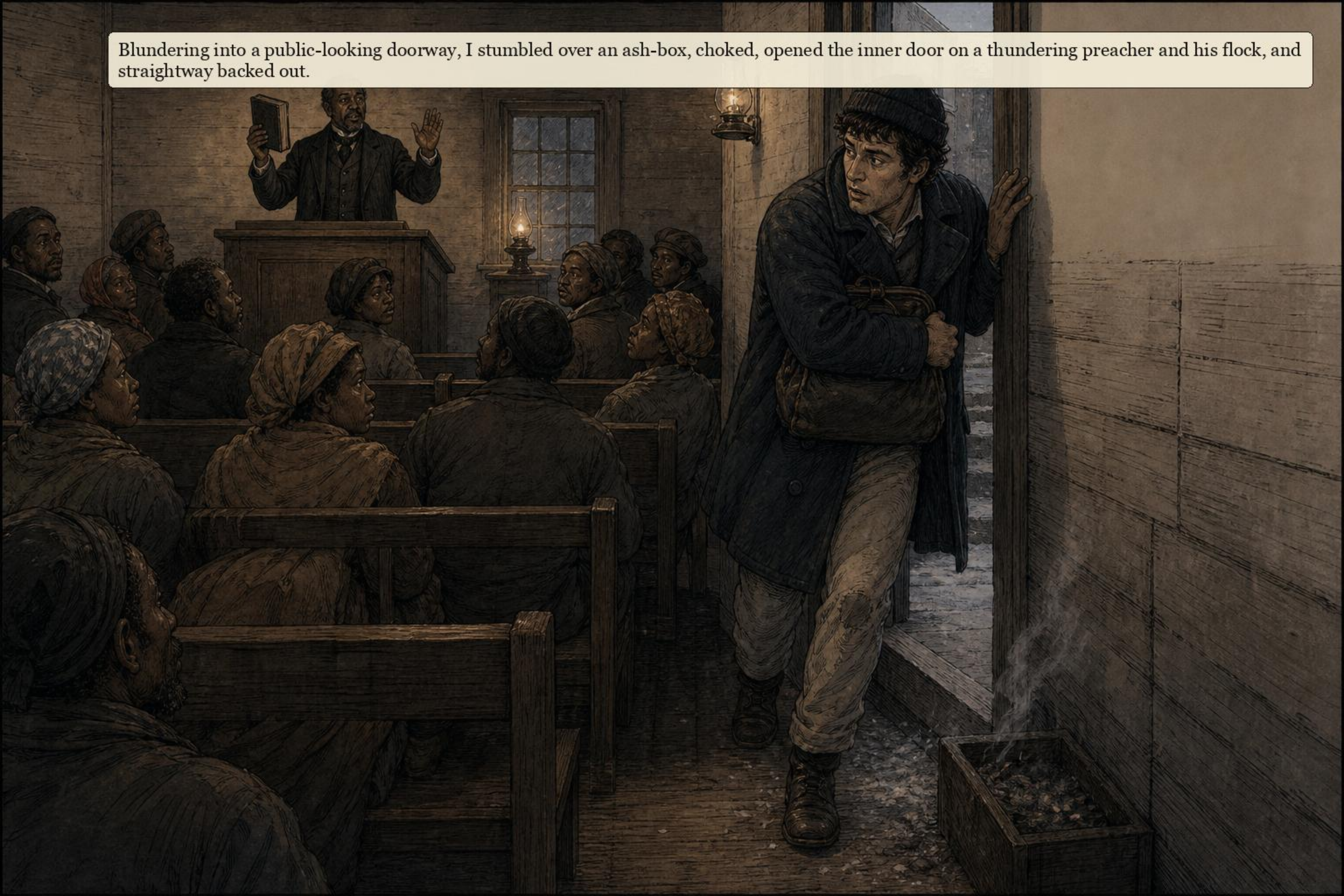
I reached New Bedford on a bitter Saturday night, only to hear the little packet for Nantucket had already sailed and none would go till Monday.



Sounding my pockets and finding only a few pieces of silver, I told myself to inquire the price and not be too particular where I lodged.

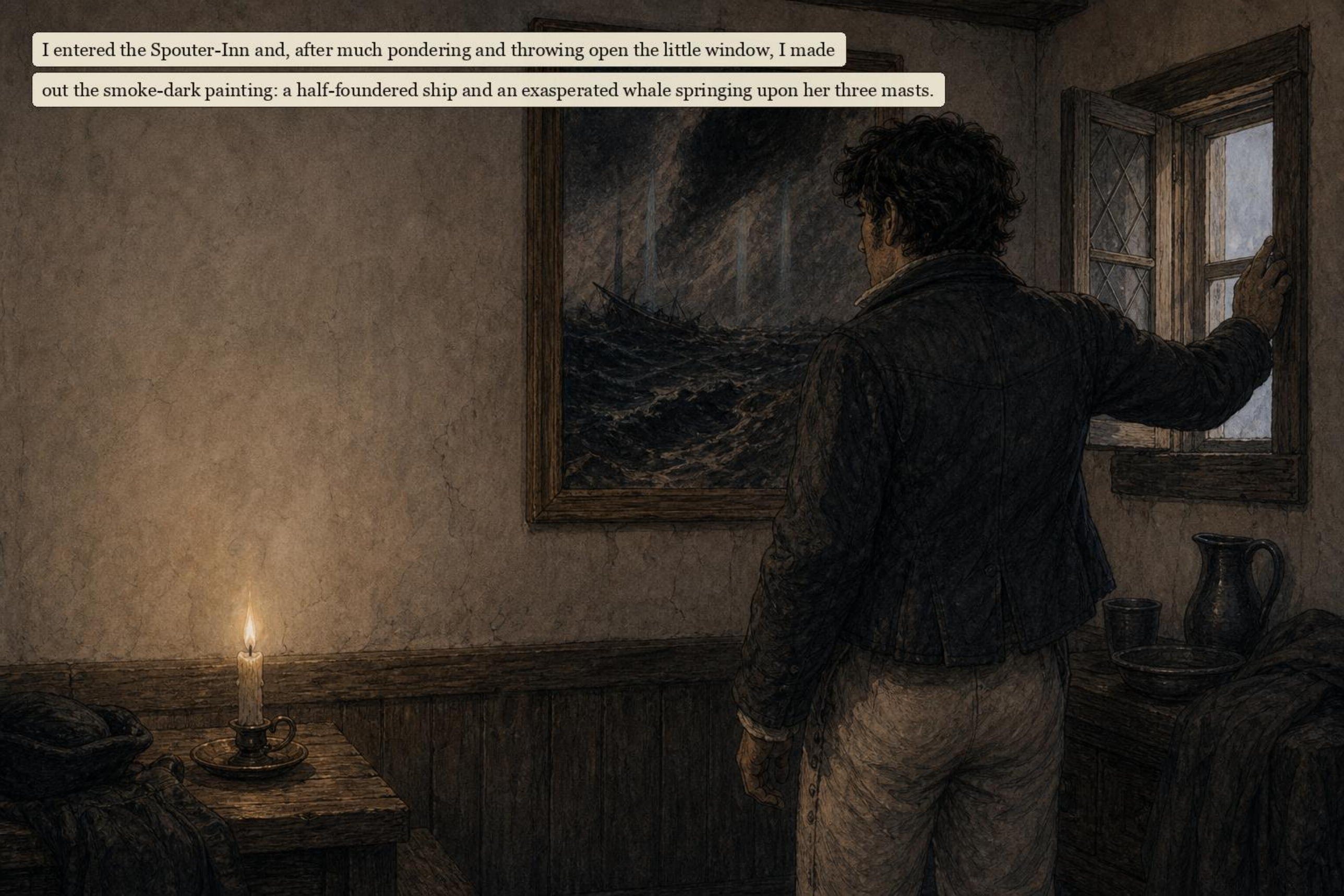


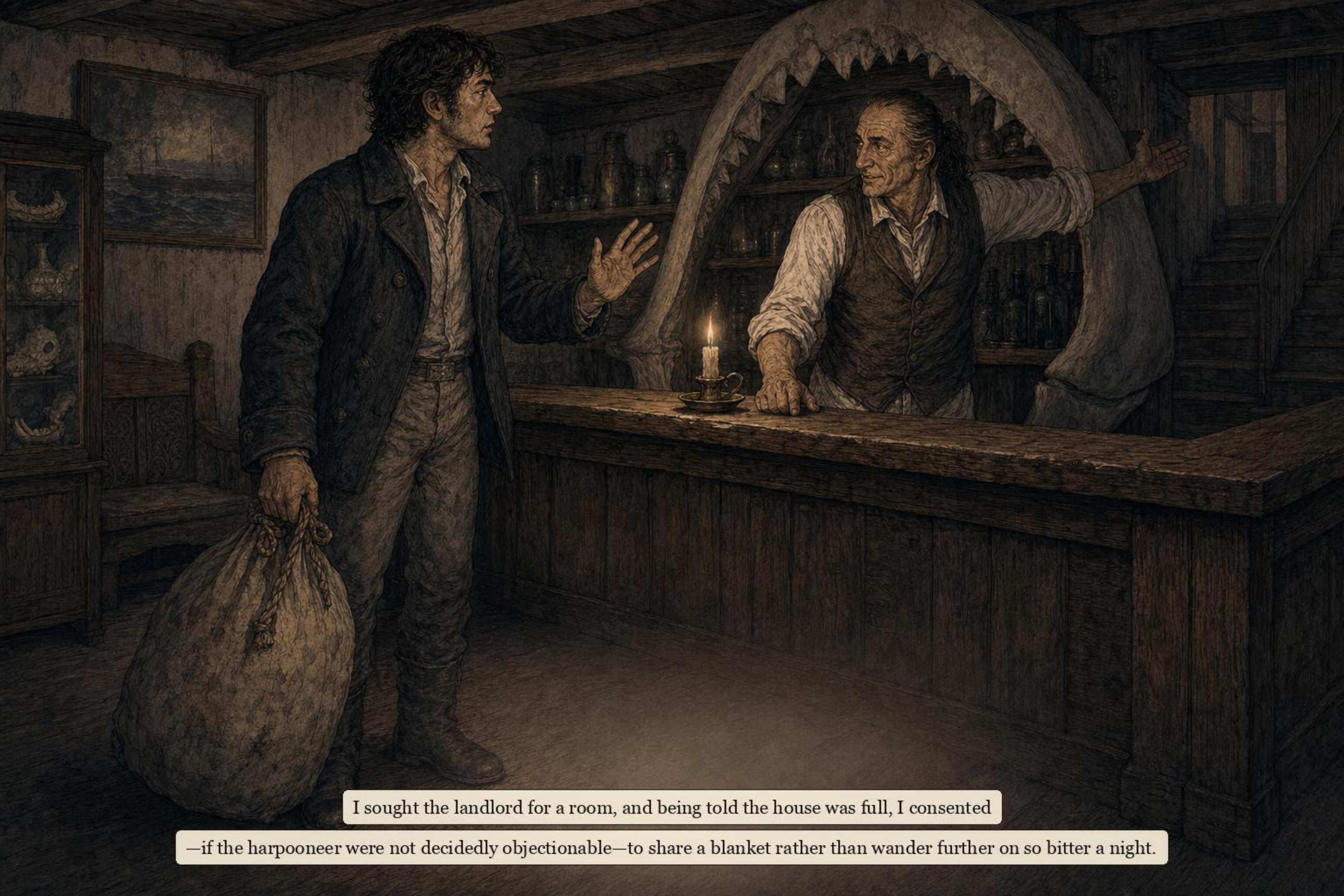
I left the Crossed Harpoons and the glowing Sword-Fish behind—too expensive and jolly—and turned waterward for cheaper inns.


Blundering into a public-looking doorway, I stumbled over an ash-box, choked, opened the inner door on a thundering preacher and his flock, and straightway backed out.

Then I saw the swinging sign with a tall jet of spray—ominous names or no—and judged this the very spot for cheap lodgings, so I made for the door.

I entered the Spouter-Inn and, after much pondering and throwing open the little window, I made out the smoke-dark painting: a half-foundered ship and an exasperated whale springing upon her three masts.





I sought the landlord for a room, and being told the house was full, I consented

—if the harpooneer were not decidedly objectionable—to share a blanket rather than wander further on so bitter a night.

I changed my mind about that harpooneer, chose the bench, and soon learned that knots, a foot too short, and the meeting draughts would never do

—while the landlord kept chuckling that the fellow was out ‘selling his head.’

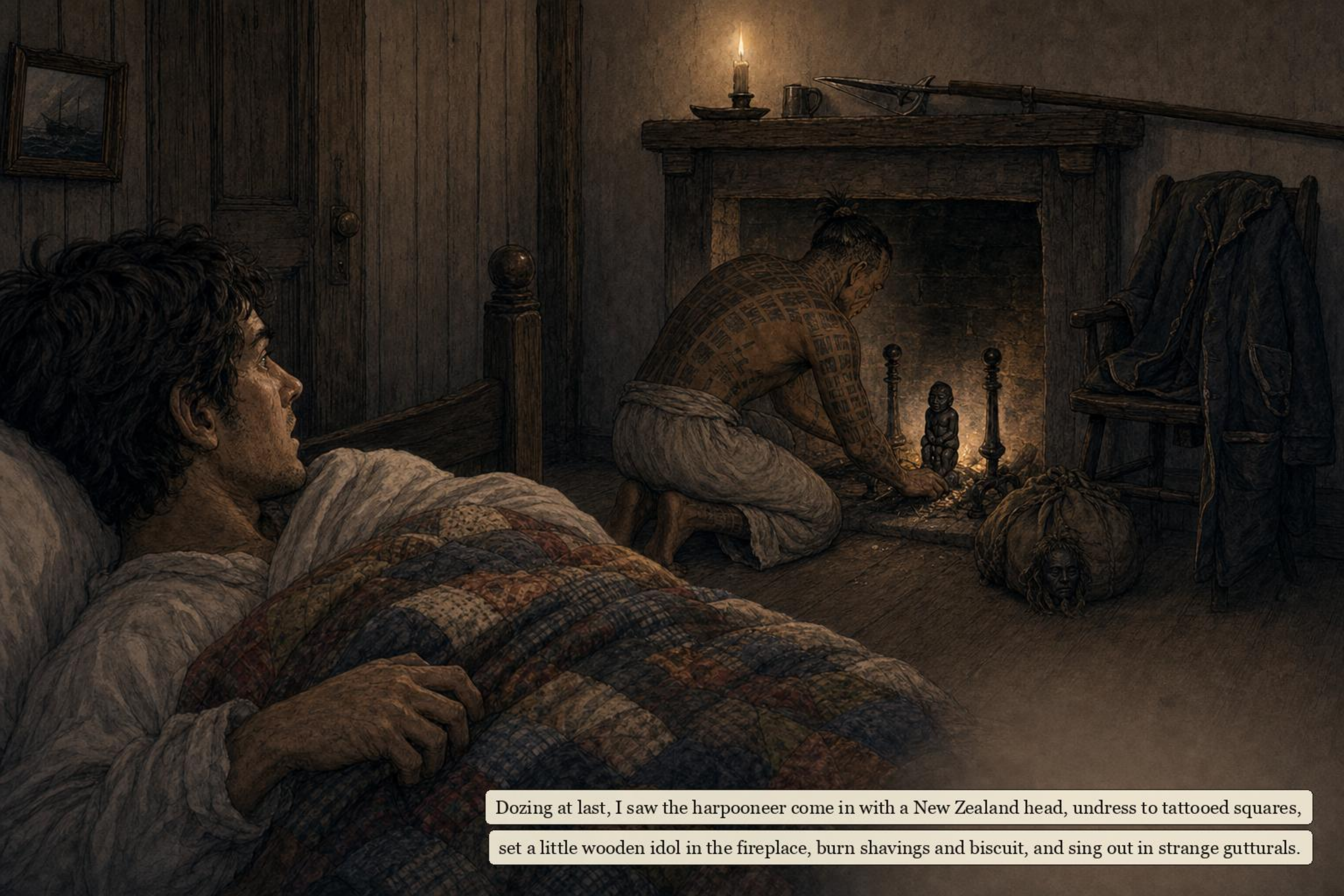




Provoked by his bamboozling yarn of selling his head, I demanded the truth, and heard it plain—embalmed New Zealand heads, peddled on a Saturday night.

Seeing it was Sunday and he'd come to anchor elsewhere, I let the landlord lead me to the prodigious bed; I eyed the room and the harpooneer's outlandish gear, then turned in.





Dozing at last, I saw the harpooneer come in with a New Zealand head, undress to tattooed squares,

set a little wooden idol in the fireplace, burn shavings and biscuit, and sing out in strange gutturals.

Then, tomahawk-pipe between his teeth, he sprang into bed with me; I sang out, and the landlord burst in with a light to swear the harpooneer, Queequeg, wouldn't harm a hair of my head.





Better sleep with a sober cannibal than a drunken Christian, thought I; he stashed the tomahawk-pipe, I turned in again, and never slept better in my life.

I woke at daylight to find Queequeg's tattooed arm thrown over me, so blended with the patchwork counterpane that only its weight told me he was hugging me.





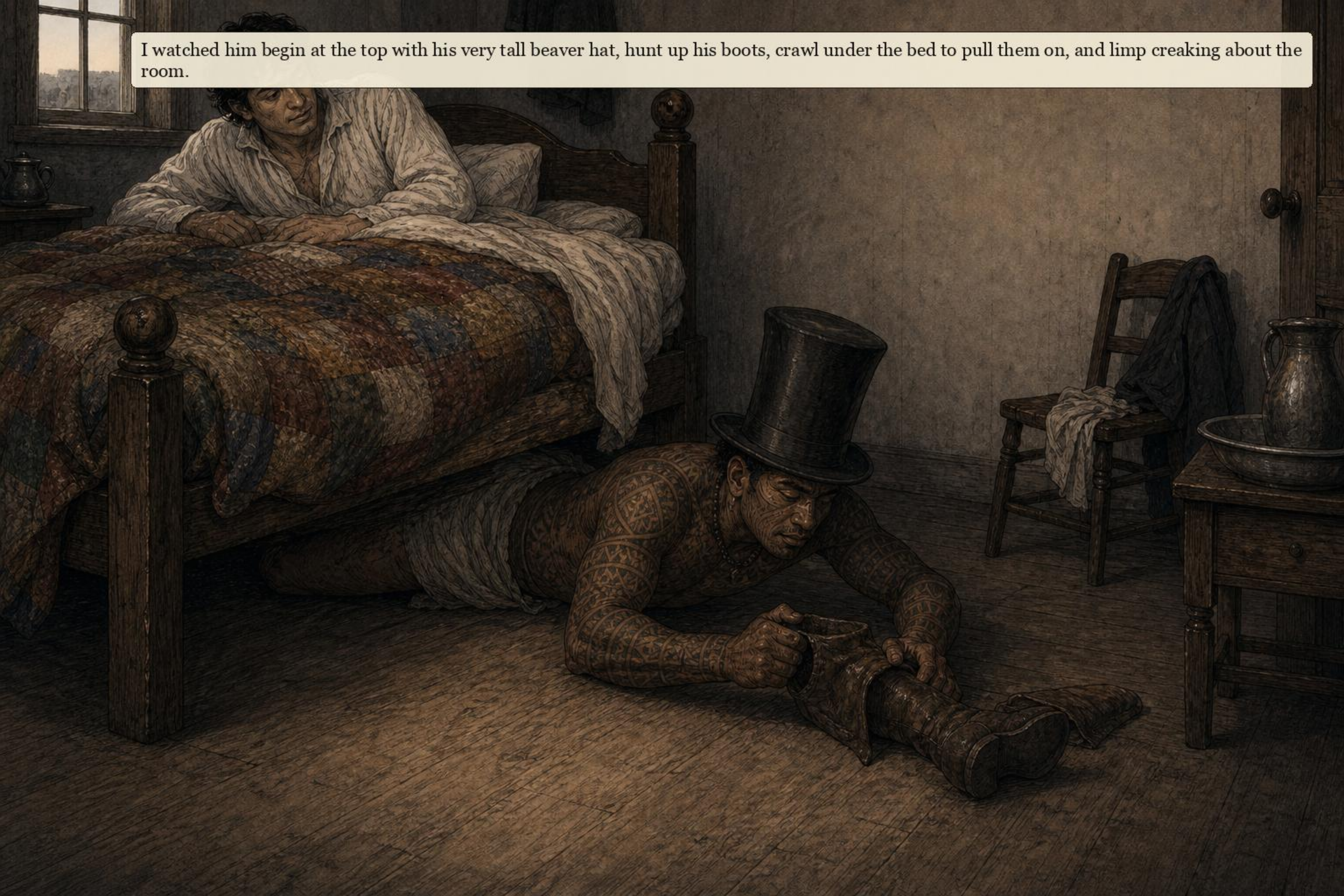
I tried to free myself and rouse him, rolled, felt a slight scratch, and, throwing aside the counterpane, I saw his tomahawk-pipe lying by his side.

By much wriggling and loud expostulations I woke him; he drew back his arm, shook himself, and sat up staring, while I lay quiet and curious rather than afraid.





He made signs that he would dress first and then leave me to dress alone—a very civilized overture I accepted as I watched him.



I watched him begin at the top with his very tall beaver hat, hunt up his boots, crawl under the bed to pull them on, and limp creaking about the room.



Seeing there were no curtains and the house opposite looked in, I begged him to hasten into his pantaloons, whereupon he complied and washed only his chest, arms, and hands.

Then I saw him coolly shave with the head of his harpoon, and, his toilet complete, he marched out in his pilot monkey jacket, sporting the harpoon like a marshal's baton.

